elephant corps was standard throughout the wars of Ptolemy, Seleucus, etc. The Romans, however, had not yet encountered them when Pyrrhus arrived with his 20+ behemoths at Heraclea. The result was typical: the Roman cavalry had a collective coronary, and the Roman infantry didn't wait around long enough to see their EKGs. By the time of Hannibal, however, the Romans were pretty much used to them and had devised some ingenious methods of negating their abilities; the effectiveness of jousting chariots and the flaming pigs of the Pyrrhic era having proved rather elusive. The elephants of Hannibal were the smaller, North African forest variety—not the big Indian tuskers that Porus had at the Hydaspes (or, for that matter, the much larger southern African variety)—and were usually equipped with towers, purportedly an invention of Pyrrhus. Pyrrhus' elephants, inherited from the Diadochi, were probably the bigger, Indian variety. War elephants were pretty much impervious to anything—except sharp, pointy objects and loud, strange noises. They also tended to have a mind of their own when annoyed, which often happened when confronted with those same sharp, pointy objects and strange sounds.